“What If We Can't All Agree?” Eight Questions Families Ask Before a Hard Care Decision

General answers in plain words, and who to take your own family's question to.

A family with a care decision in front of it keeps running into the same few questions. Here are eight of them, answered in general terms.

The answers aren't about your loved one or your family in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows the situation, the note under the answer says who that is.

1 How do we find out what our loved one actually wants?

Ask them, and write down what they say in their own words. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. A broad question can be hard to answer on the spot, so ask an everyday one, such as what a good day looks like for them. If they'd rather not talk about it yet, the Institute's advice is to start simple, with any concerns they have, and come back to it another time. [1] [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** they've told you what they want and you can't tell what it would take to honor it. That belongs to the people who assess their situation.

2 Should our loved one be at the family meeting?

The sources lean toward including them. The National Institute on Aging suggests a meeting or call with the older person and everyone who will be involved in their care, and the Family Caregiver Alliance, writing about the person receiving care, says family members usually do not want to be excluded from family events and that their preferences for care must be considered. If your loved one might misunderstand what the meeting is for, the Alliance says a family may hold a first meeting without them and a second with them present. Either way, start with what they have said. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure how best to include your loved one in a conversation like this. Their doctor or a social worker is the person to ask.

3 How do we find out where we really agree and disagree?

Ask every relative involved the same few questions, what worries you most, what do you hope for, what can you do yourself, and put the answers side by side. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a successful family meeting gives everyone a chance to be heard, and that even when disagreeing it helps to find the part of what was said that you can agree with. Then write two lists, where we agree and where we don't, in words each person would accept. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the lists are written and you'd like someone neutral to go through them with the family.

4 What if we can't all agree?

Then write the disagreement down plainly and keep it in view. The Family Caregiver Alliance says not all the issues in caregiving and decision-making can be solved, and that sometimes it is important to accept approximations of a good solution. It also reminds families that a meeting is not a one-time event, so not everything has to be resolved in one sitting. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family is divided on something big. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it often helps to invite a neutral outside facilitator, and names social workers, ministers, private case managers, physicians and hospital discharge planners as people who can do that or refer you.

5 One of us does most of the talking. How do we make sure everyone is heard?

Give everyone the same questions and the same space on the page, whether they answer in two lines or two pages. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests preparing an agenda and sending it out beforehand so others can add to it. AARP's planning guide notes that an outside facilitator, such as a social worker or minister, can help keep everyone focused. [5] [6] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** meetings keep going back to old arguments. The Family Caregiver Alliance says an objective professional can help a family stay on the topic at hand.

6 Who gets to decide?

This guide can't answer that for your family. What the sources do say is where a plan starts: AARP's planning guide says every family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without their participation, knowledge and consent. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests putting the question itself, who will make decisions and how, on the meeting's agenda so it is talked about openly. [6] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** there's a question about who has the authority to decide for your loved one. That is a legal question for an attorney. It isn't one for this guide or for a family vote.

7 What if our loved one can't tell us clearly what they want?

Ask anyway, and write down which notes are their words and which are the family's memory of them. The Institute for Healthcare Improvement, in guidance for health systems, says older adults living with cognitive impairment are often capable of expressing their goals and preferences and should take part in these conversations to the degree possible. For a person who can no longer decide, the National Institute on Aging suggests thinking about how they lived their life: the values and wishes they expressed in the past, and what they found most meaningful. [8] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're unsure how much your loved one can take part in this decision. Ask their doctor. It isn't something for the family to judge alone.

8 What do we need to find out before we decide?

Whatever the decision depends on that nobody in the family actually knows. List each open question beside the person who could answer it: your loved one, a relative, a doctor or nurse, a social worker, a care consultant. For the medical ones, the National Institute on Aging suggests bringing a written list to the appointment, starting with the most important, and taking notes so the answers can be shared with the other caregivers. [9]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a question on the list is about your loved one's health, abilities or safety. Take it to their doctor or nurse. It isn't something to settle by family agreement.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your loved one or say what your family should choose. Anything that depends on their health, their abilities, their safety or who has legal authority needs a professional who knows the situation.

Ready for the next step?

You have general answers to the questions your family keeps running into. The care interview asks the particular ones: it goes through your loved one's situation one area at a time, so what the family wants sits beside what is actually going on, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
3. National Institute on Aging, Advance Care Planning and Health Care Decisions: Tips for Caregivers and Families
4. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
8. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
9. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers